

House of Commons
William Pitt the Younger, the British prime minister, addressing the House of Commons in 1793, about a year after the failure of a pivotal antislavery debate.



“Africa! Africa! Your sufferings have... arrested my heart.”

WILBERFORCE, HOUSE OF COMMONS, 1792

writing to Addington that he proposed to give up as the “active and chief agent in terminating the trade.” Pitt was returned to power in 1804 and Wilberforce’s biographers claim that the “abolition business” had again become his chief care, yet he only attended three meetings of the Abolition Society that year, and a further three in 1805.

William Pitt died prematurely in 1806. A Whig government under Addington was returned, and in 1807 the antislavery trade bill was trundled out again. Wilberforce spoke only briefly, late in the debate.

Lord Howick, a leading advocate of abolition, delivered the main motion, dispensing with rhetorical flourishes and presenting hard economic facts. The House of Lords was won over and passed the Trade Abolition Bill on March 23, 1807.

Withdrawing from public life

Wilberforce increasingly claimed bouts of malaise that prevented him from attending debates that he guessed were likely to prove unpopular. Rhetoric also worked against him. On July 29, 1811 he wrote to a friend complaining of adverse press treatment, claiming, “I am often left out and more frequently dismissed with a much shorter account of what I have said...”. He began to question if he should resign his seat in Parliament, and on September 8, 1812 declared his intention to step down. A month later he took on the seat of Bramber in Sussex.



Symbol of suffering

A sculpture of a kneeling and chained enslaved African man, whose image was identified with the antislavery movement.

At this time, he consistently denied interest in abolition. When debate was launched in earnest in 1823, he became a virtual bystander in the House

of Commons and also in the recently formed Anti-Slavery Society. He was persuaded to table a radical petition on behalf of

the Quaker Society of Friends, calling for abolition of slavery in the British dominions, but wrote in his diary, “I wish that Buxton or Whitmore



Abolition

This engraving, by the British artist Joseph Collyer, shows the figure of Britannia examining the bill abolishing the British slave trade, on March 23, 1807.

should take chief management of the slave’s concerns and let me give occasional assistance as my indifferent health and infirmities will allow.”

In July 1828 he wrote scathingly to the new emancipation champion, Fowell Buxton, about the Duke of Wellington’s pro-slavery position, yet he still took no more active involvement other than the symbolic chairing of an Anti-Slavery Society meeting in 1830. He passed away on July 29, 1833, without witnessing the final enactment of the emancipation bill on August 20, which was prompted less by the work of any individual than by a major slave uprising in Jamaica at the close of 1831.

ABOLITIONIST (1745–97)

OLAUDAH EQUIANO

Born in what is now Nigeria, Equiano wrote an influential autobiography, which was published in 1789 and detailed his life as a slave. Captured in West Africa at age 11, he was shipped to Barbados, and then to Virginia, where a Royal Navy officer bought him, taught him to read and write, and named him Gustavus Vassa after the Swedish king. Sold again, he was taken to Montserrat, in the Caribbean, where he bought his freedom. He moved to London in 1786 and became involved with the abolition movement. He married an English woman in 1792, but died five years later.



TIMELINE

- **August 24, 1759** Born in Hull, the third of the four children of Robert and Elizabeth Wilberforce.
- **1776** Enters St. John’s College, Cambridge, with two scholarships, after attending St. Paul’s School in London.
- **September 1779** Runs for and wins the parliamentary seat of Hull at a personal cost of over £8,000 (\$34,000).
- **1784–85** Begins a period of intense religious reflection, consulting John Newton, antislavery campaigner. He joins the “Clapham Saints” and becomes a fervent evangelical Christian.
- **May 22, 1787** The London Committee for the Abolition of the Slave Trade is founded by Thomas Clarkson and others. **JOHN NEWTON**
- **October 30, 1787** Wilberforce makes his first contact with the London Committee.
- **1788** Awarded Master of Arts Degree.
- **February 11, 1788** Gains William Pitt’s support for the unpopular move to place responsibility for examining the slave trade and abolition with the Privy Council.
- **May 12, 1789** Makes his first major speech in the House of Commons.
- **April 19, 1791** Opts for confrontation and brings a full abolition motion before the House of Commons against advice. The motion is defeated by a large majority.
- **June 7, 1791** First attends a meeting of the London Committee.
- **April 2, 1792** Robustly denies interest in slave emancipation. Full anti-slave-trade debate in parliament overwhelmingly defeated.
- **May 30, 1797** Marries Barbara Ann Spooner, a landowner’s daughter, after a two-week courtship.
- **1802** Organizes Society for the Suppression of Vice.
- **March 23, 1807** Bill against the slave trade carries in the House of Lords after a successful motion, presented by Lord Howick and Sir Samuel Romilly.
- **1812** Wilberforce resigns from his Hull seat. He represents Bramber, in Sussex, until retirement.
- **March 18, 1823** Presents radical petition in the Commons on behalf of the dissident Society of Friends for abolition in all British Dominions.
- **June 11, 1823** Wilberforce gives his last speech in the House of Commons.
- **1825** Retires from Parliament.
- **1830** Makes his last public appearance, chairing a meeting of the Anti-Slavery Society.
- **July 29, 1833** William Wilberforce dies in London.
- **August 3, 1833** State funeral held for Wilberforce in Westminster Abbey.